

marketing emphasis on this element of the survey misses the point—and that is that, although this survey will not provide a definitive summary of the secrets of the sexual life of modern India in the new millennium, it does present a fascinating glimpse of several secret issues that need to be discussed and considered. Some of these secrets are sexy, and some are secret because they are dark and dreadful, and these in particular demand to be spoken about openly and in public.

In fact, it is no great secret that men and women, men and men and women and women have sex in India. We all know the world over that people have sex. The problem with surveys is that whilst they secure confidentiality, the respondents are also unable to obtain clarification about what the question means. Is sex *sharirik bandhan* (bodily relations), heterosexual or homosexual play, penetration or what Bill Clinton famously considered to be “not sex”. It isn’t that we need a hard and fast rule—indeed, anthropologists would be curious about the culturally specific ways in which different actors in diverse societies and settings describe and think about relations of affect and intimacy. Surveys such as this de-contextualise sexual practice from social settings and assume a uniformity of meaning when we are uncertain that any actually exists. I am fascinated however, by some of the themes that emerge both in respect of the surveyors’ agenda and of course, what the responses are telling us. Whilst it is hard to draw an anthropological insight from statistics about the 62 per cent of respondents who frequently watch pornography or the top of the league status for the missionary position, the survey presents us with a whole constellation of behaviours that are eminently social. Small bits of information about the contours of practices such as incest, adulterous sex with ex-boyfriends and girlfriends in a country with predominantly parentally arranged marriages, sex with eunuchs and prostitutes (both male and female), under-age sex, non-consensual sex and force all constitute

subjects with a tremendous significance for Indian society and indeed for the anthropological study of sexuality and intimacy in India today.

We learn that 28 per cent of Indian respondents have had sex before the age of 20. It is interesting that in this survey, the question wasn’t directed specifically at the number of people who have had sex before the heterosexual legal age of consent for non-marital sex, as if this were a non-issue.

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THE SURVEY’S IMPLICIT MESSAGE IS THAT WHILST MARRIAGE MAY WELL CONTINUE TO BE ABOUT APPROPRIATE ARRANGEMENT, SEXUALITY IN INDIA IS WHERE PEOPLE HAVE CHOICE

Worryingly, 6 per cent of these constitute sex before the teens, and may be read as a potential child abuse indicator that gets flagged under another question about sexual consent to which I will return. Twelve per cent of all respondents reported that their first sexual encounter was without their consent and we might reasonably expect that most, if not all, of the 6 per cent who said that they had pre-teen sex were victims of sexual abuse.

To an anthropologist, there is a striking absence in the survey of anything to do with those apparently “core” identities that govern so many Indian marital (and by extension, sexual) arrangements—that is, not a sniff of caste or religion in any of the ques-

tions. Its implicit message is that whilst marriage may well continue to be about appropriate arrangement, sexuality in India is where people have choice! And yet some of the survey’s findings are surprisingly domestic. Seventy-four per cent of all respondents don’t approve of adultery, and those who do are found to have been adulterous themselves. Sixty-seven per cent of respondents—presumably from the disapproving camp, do not even deign to answer the next question as to whether or not they have been adulterous—a more familiar situation of cultural context creeping into the survey through the powerful mode of a resolute silence. Twenty-six per cent do, however, confess that they have been adulterous (with a further 1 per cent having contemplated it), and of these there are five times more men confessing adultery than women. Another fascinating revelation is that 13 per cent men and 4 per cent women who have had sex say their first sexual encounter was with a neighbour. Neighbours feature again in figures on adultery: when asked to choose from seven categories of person with whom respondents had

been adulterous, high on the list (after former boyfriends and girlfriends) come those who cheated on their marriage with a neighbour.

Of those who were sexually active, 4 per cent of men and 4 per cent of women reported that they had their first sexual relations with a relative. Nearly 8 per cent of those married respondents who admitted to adultery (12/156) said they were adulterous with a relative. If we just take this idea, about the 4 per cent of people who appear to have had their first sexual experience with relatives (note: only 2 per cent answered that they had had sex with “blood relatives” in a question about the incidence of incest, so here the 4 per cent figure in-